

Event Resource: Considerations for Sustainability in Event Planning

Event Resource: Considerations for Sustainability in Event Planning

Considerations for Planning Sustainable Activities

Planning events with sustainability in mind is not only good for our environment, but it can also save money.

Transportation

- If you are taking a large group of students off-campus, consider chartering a bus
- Consider organizing a group walk or bike ride to nearby off-campus events
- If you are going to a location near the Minneapolis campus, consider taking the campus shuttle

Planning Meetings/Events

- Virtual meetings eliminate the time and energy of transportation
- Ask members to bring their own drinking containers to eliminate disposable cup waste
- Email agendas ahead of time and print only when necessary
 - Consider other options for presenting the information digitally, and when you do print, always recycle the paper when you are done with it

Catering

- When you order catering, try to only order what will get eaten
 - Keeping track of what gets eaten at prior events and tracking attendance will help you adjust for future orders
- Depending on the event or meeting, ask if your attendees can bring their own reusable cups, utensils, bowls, or plates
- Consider healthy food options with lower environmental impact

- Plant-based items generally have lower water and carbon footprint than animal proteins

Avoiding Waste

- Use what you have before buying something new
 - Updating previously used trifolds saves time and minimizes waste
 - See if other communities have resources you can borrow
 - Try to repair broken club equipment or items instead of throwing them away and buying something new
- Avoid using single use products that will be thrown away after events or meetings, such as printed agendas or event supplies. If necessary, consider compostable items.
- Properly sort your waste for events
 - You can request extra bins for trash, compost, or recycling through your 25-Live event request if your event is going to produce more waste than the bins in your event space can handle.
 - Compost organic material such as food, napkins, and BPI certified compostable products. A good rule to go by is if it was once alive, it is compostable.

BPI certified compostable product symbol

- For recycling, be mindful of the numbers listed on the items. Recycle clean paper, glass, cardboard, metal, and plastics (numbered 1, 2, and 5).

Plastic recycling symbols, numbered 1, 2, and 5

- Do not recycle items that have been soiled with food or other contaminants (although they may be able to be composted instead if they are BPI certified).
- Some items need to be recycled separately such as batteries, light bulbs, plastic bags, and plastic film. They can be recycled in the create[space] and in the campus store in Murray-Herrick.

Special recycling bin for batteries, light bulbs, plastic bags, and plastic film

- “When in doubt, throw it out” – if you don’t know if an item should be recycled/composted or not, it’s better to throw it away than take the risk of contaminating the recycling/composting bin.
- Consider making an announcement about what items can be recycled, composed and thrown away. If you are using a slide show, consider adding a slide with this information.

Giveaways Considerations:

- As a whole, giveaways generate waste. So really consider if a giveaway item is even necessary to the success when tabling or hosting an event.
- Choose useable giveaways that promote sustainable behaviors.
- Consider a drawing for one big item rather than giving a lot of smaller items away that may not get used or will end up in the trash.
- When giving away treats/candy, choose products with minimal, recyclable, and/or compostable packaging.

Additional Resources

- [Guide to Campus Sustainability \(https://one.stthomas.edu/media/12022/guide-to-sustainability-at-st-thomas-3.pdf\)](https://one.stthomas.edu/media/12022/guide-to-sustainability-at-st-thomas-3.pdf)
- [Sustainability Digital Badges](https://one.stthomas.edu/sites/sustainability/SitePageModern/168447/sustainability-essentials-digital-badge) 
(https://one.stthomas.edu/sites/sustainability/SitePageModern/168447/sustainability-essentials-digital-badge)
- [Guide to Hosting Sustainable Events \(https://one.stthomas.edu/media/13062/guide-to-hosting-sustainable-events-2.pdf\)](https://one.stthomas.edu/media/13062/guide-to-hosting-sustainable-events-2.pdf)
- [Office of Sustainability Initiatives \(OneStThomas\)](https://one.stthomas.edu/sites/sustainability/SitePageModern/78024/campus-initiatives) 
(https://one.stthomas.edu/sites/sustainability/SitePageModern/78024/campus-initiatives)
- [Office of Sustainability Initiatives \(Public Website\)](https://www.stthomas.edu/about/sustainability/osi/index.html) 
(https://www.stthomas.edu/about/sustainability/osi/index.html)

Contact

- Rachel Schauer, rschauer@stthomas.edu (mailto:rschauer@stthomas.edu)